

Popout — Product Requirements & Research

Find something to do. Find someone to do it with.

2026-09-17 · @Someone

Summary

Popout is a map-first web product that answers two questions: what can I do around me, and who can I do it with. Launch market is Bangalore, one dense area first.

The map carries two kinds of pins. **Events** are things already happening nearby — a comedy show, a bowling offer, live music, a pottery workshop. **Popouts** are small casual plans created by ordinary users: "coffee and conversation, Third Wave, 8 PM, 2 of 4 joined."

A Popout is not a formal event. It is a temporary social flare — *I am doing this, anyone nearby want to come?* Typical size is 2–6 people, typical horizon is the next 24 hours, and it leaves the active map once it has happened.

The two halves connect. Find an event you want to attend but nobody to go with, and the event page offers to find you company: join a crew, or start one. Discovery creates the occasion; Popouts supply the people.

Positioning	Find something to do. Find someone to do it with.
Primary object	The activity, not the person
Launch city	Bangalore
Status	Pre-MVP. No code, no users, no inventory.

Grandmother test. "Suppose you want to go somewhere but don't know where. Popout shows interesting things happening nearby. And if you find something you like but have nobody to go with, Popout finds you nearby people who also want to go."

The problem

Adults have no low-cost way to signal that they are open to company right now. Everything else about making friends in a new city is solved advice; this one step is not.

The origin case: moving to Bangalore alone, into a 1BHK, introverted. The standard advice is go outside, join communities, approach people, find someone reading a book on Church Street and ask what they are reading.

That advice fails at the same point every time. You cannot tell whether the stranger wants to be approached. And if you do approach and they answer, there is no shared reason to keep talking. There is no social context and no mutual consent.

The missing primitive is a **declared, time-boxed, public intent to do something with someone**. Once that exists, approaching is not an imposition — it is accepting an invitation that was already offered.

Three distinct jobs sit underneath this, and they are often confused:

Job	What the user is missing	Does Popout address it
I don't know what to do	Options	Yes — the events layer
I know what to do, but have nobody to go with	Company	Yes — the Popouts layer
I know what and who, but can't make myself go	Nerve	Partly — small groups and a named host lower the cost

The third is the one most products ignore and the one that quietly decides whether anybody shows up.

Who it is for

The primary user is someone who arrived in Bangalore in the last six months, lives alone or with strangers, works a desk job, and has no weekend social default.

Primary — the newcomer. Age 22–32. Tech, design, consulting, startups, or a first job. Has money and time but no local network. Willing to meet strangers because the alternative is another weekend alone. This person supplies the early demand and, critically, the early hosts.

Secondary — the solo attendee. Already has some friends, but not friends who want to do *this* specific thing tonight. Wants the comedy show, the trek, the badminton court, and needs one or three more people. Lower loneliness, higher intent, easier to convert because the activity is already chosen.

Tertiary — the existing friend group. Three to five people already together, asking "what should we do?" They do not need people, only options. They are a retention hypothesis, not a launch audience, and the doc treats them as unproven.

Explicitly not the user in V1: couples looking for double dates, people seeking romance, tourists, under-18s, and anyone wanting large-format Meetup-style events.

Product principles

These are the rules a feature has to survive. If a proposed feature breaks one, it does not ship, however good the metric looks.

1. **The activity is the primary object, not the person.** We match person to situation, never person to person. No swiping, no browsing people, no "nearby users" list. Age and gender are eligibility filters on a Popout, never a matchmaking surface.
2. **We do not own the friendship.** Once people meet, they will move to WhatsApp, and that is correct. WhatsApp will always beat us at maintaining an existing relationship. We own the question "what should we do", not the relationship.
3. **Small and soon beats large and scheduled.** Default Popout is 2–6 people within 24 hours. Large formats are somebody else's product.
4. **A plan that does not happen is worse than no plan.** One no-show ruins a user permanently. Reliability outranks selection, volume, and discovery.
5. **Never show an empty map.** A pin count of zero is an unrecoverable first impression. If there is nothing nearby, we widen the radius, show the next best thing, or show a single seeded Popout — but never nothing.
6. **Lightest possible identity.** Google sign-in, a name, an age, a photo. No phone OTP, no Aadhaar, no KYC until the core behaviour is proven.
7. **Every Popout is a public page.** Shareable to WhatsApp, viewable without an account. Sign-up happens at the moment of joining, not before.
8. **Ship nothing that requires a recommendation engine to be useful.** If the product only works with good ranking, the product does not work.

Core concepts

Five objects. Everything in V1 is built out of these.

Object	What it is	Created by	Lifespan
Popout	A small plan open for people to join	A user (the host)	Until it starts, plus a grace window

Object	What it is	Created by	Lifespan
Event	Something already happening at a venue	Popout team or an organizer	Until it ends
Crew	A Popout attached to an Event, for going together	A user, from the event page	Until the event starts
Host	The user accountable for a Popout or Crew	—	Persistent
Member	A user who joined a Popout or Crew	—	Per Popout

A **Crew** is not a sixth object in the database. It is a Popout with an `event_id` set. Same table, same join flow, same chat. This keeps the model small and means every improvement to Popouts improves Crews for free.

```

flowchart LR
    E[Event<br/>venue supply] -->|find company| C[Crew]
    U[User] -->|creates| P[Popout]
    U -->|creates| C
    C --> M[Members 2-6]
    P --> M
    M -->|meet in person| F[Friendship<br/>leaves to WhatsApp]
    F -. ->|what should we do| E

```

The dotted line is the retention bet. It is the least proven arrow in the diagram and section 10 treats it as a risk rather than a fact.

User journeys

Four journeys carry the whole product. Everything in V1 exists to serve one of them.

A. Discover and join

User opens Popout and lands on a map centred on their location. Pins show distance, time and fill state.

Coffee	800m	8:00 PM	2/4
Evening walk	1.2km	in 30 min	1/3
Comedy night	2.0km	tonight	Rs 399
Bowling	1.5km	tonight	20% off
Dinner	900m	8:30 PM	3/4

Tapping a pin opens a sheet: title, venue, time, who is going, the host's name, age and one-line bio, who is eligible, and a single primary action. Joining is one tap for a signed-in user, and sign-in plus join for everyone else.

After joining, the user sees the small group and a thread to coordinate in. Then they physically meet.

B. Create a Popout

Nothing on the map appeals, so the user taps **Create Popout**. The form is deliberately short — six fields, one screen, under sixty seconds.

Field	Example	Required
What	Coffee and random conversation	Yes
Where	Third Wave Coffee, Indiranagar	Yes
When	Today, 8:00 PM	Yes
Max people	4	Yes, default 4
Who can join	Anyone, 22-32	No, defaults open
Description	New to Bangalore. Come have coffee.	No

On publish, a pin appears on the map and the host gets a shareable link.

C. Event plus find company

User finds an event they want but has nobody to go with. The event page carries a second block under the booking link: **Going alone? Find people to go with.**

```

flowchart LR
    A[Event page] --> B{Have company?}
    B -->|No| C[Join a crew<br/>Rahul 2/4]
    B -->|No| D[Create a crew]
    B -->|Yes| E[Book directly]
    C --> F[Crew chat]
    D --> F
    F --> G[Attend together]
```

This is the join between the two halves of the product. Event discovery produces social interaction as a side effect, which is cheaper than manufacturing social interaction directly.

D. Invite and share

Every Popout and Event has a public URL that renders fully without an account. Two flows use it.

Host fills their own Popout. A Popout at 1 of 4 prompts *share to fill your Popout*. The host pastes the link into WhatsApp, an office group, or a community server.

User invites a specific friend. From any event page, *Invite* produces a WhatsApp message: "Shuvam wants you to Popout. Stand-up tonight, 8 PM, Koramangala. Join Shuvam." The recipient sees the page immediately; authentication happens only if they decide to join.

Every Popout is therefore its own acquisition page. Three parties distribute it: the guest inviting a friend, the host filling seats, and the organizer promoting their event.

MVP scope (V1)

V1 is a mobile-web app, not a native app. Nine features. If a tenth is proposed, one of these nine has to come out.

#	Feature	Acceptance criteria
1	Google sign-in	User signs in with Google in one tap. Session persists. No phone, no OTP, no password.
2	Profile	Name, age, gender, area, photo, one-line bio. Photo defaults to the Google avatar. Completable in under 30 seconds.
3	Map	Opens on the user's location, or Indiranagar if location is denied. Shows Popout and Event pins with distance, time and fill state. Never renders zero pins.
4	List view	The same results as a list, sorted by start time. Works when the map fails or location is denied.
5	Popout detail	Title, venue, time, host with bio, current members, eligibility, fill state, one primary action. Renders fully to signed-out visitors.
6	Create Popout	The six-field form from journey B. Publishes in under 60 seconds and returns a share link.
7	Join and leave	One tap to join if eligible and not full. Leaving is allowed and frees the seat. Host sees who joined.

#	Feature	Acceptance criteria
8	Group thread	A simple message thread per Popout, visible only to members. Realtime. No media, no reactions, no DMs.
9	Share	Every Popout and Event has a public URL with correct WhatsApp link previews. One-tap share to WhatsApp.

Events in V1

Events are entered manually by the Popout team. There is no organizer dashboard, no self-serve listing, and no ticketing. An Event links out to the organizer's existing booking page. We take no commission and hold no payment.

This is deliberate. Manual entry is the cheapest way to test whether event supply drives usage, and it postpones the entire B2B product surface until there is evidence to justify it.

The safety floor

Three things ship in V1 regardless of schedule pressure: a report button on every profile and Popout, a block function that hides both users from each other, and a host-level removal of any member from their own Popout. These are not phase-two items.

Non-goals for V1 quality

V1 does not need to be fast, beautiful, offline-capable, or accessible beyond basic keyboard and contrast standards. It needs to be correct about time, location and who is in a group. Wrong start times and duplicate joins destroy trust faster than an ugly interface does.

Explicitly out of scope

Each of these is a real feature request that will surface. Each has a reason to wait and a condition that would unlock it.

Not building	Why	Revisit when
Native iOS and Android apps	Web ships in weeks, updates instantly, and every link opens. App install is a conversion wall at the worst moment.	Weekly retained users pass roughly 1,000, or push notifications become the main coordination channel
Recommendation or ranking engine	With under 50 live Popouts, sorting by time and distance is optimal. Ranking is a solution to abundance we do not have.	More than 30 relevant Popouts per user per session
Phone OTP verification	Costs money per send and blocks sign-up. Google sign-in carries comparable weak identity for free.	First safety incident, or the fraud rate makes it cheaper than the alternative
Government ID, Aadhaar, DigiLocker	Heavy compliance and data liability before the core behaviour is proven. Would stop sign-ups cold.	Proven repeat meeting behaviour plus a real trust ceiling
Follower graph, feed, profiles as a destination	Turns the activity-first product into a people-first product. Breaks principle 1.	Never, in this form
In-app DMs	Invites one-to-one contact with strangers, which is the main harassment vector. Group-only chat is the safety design.	Not before a reputation system exists
Payments, ticketing, commissions	Adds refunds, disputes, tax and compliance to a product with no proven demand.	Organizers ask for it and volume justifies it
Organizer self-serve dashboard	Fifty events are faster to enter by hand than to build a CMS for.	Past roughly 50 recurring organizer partners
Ratings and reviews of people	Numeric scores on humans invite gaming, retaliation and cruelty. Attendance is a better signal than opinion.	Behavioural signals alone stop separating good from bad

Not building	Why	Revisit when
AI matching, chatbots, itinerary generation	No data to learn from and no problem it solves at this size.	Not in the first year
Multi-city launch	Density is local. Two half-full cities are worse than one full neighbourhood.	One Bangalore area reaches self-sustaining supply

The hardest one to hold will be in-app DMs. Users will ask for it constantly. It stays out.

Competitive landscape

The core Popout concept is not novel, and at least three products already ship it almost exactly. This section records that plainly so no later decision is made on the assumption of novelty.

The direct overlaps

Product	What it does, per its own site	Overlap with Popout
SpurSpace	Drop a pin on a map, add what you are doing and when, nearby people join in one tap and meet in person. Claims identity-verified users.	Near-total. This is the Popout create-and-join flow as described.
WorldFlows	Live map of nearby meetups ("Zelos") and events. Post your own plan with destination, date and intent. Event chat so you can <i>find company to go with instead of skipping it.</i>	Near-total, including the Crew mechanic. The event-plus-find-company flow we treated as the connecting insight already exists here.
PlsTouchGrass	IRL-first casual hangouts nearby, map or feed. Find a hangout, join the chat, show up. Live in Bangalore with a curated 189-venue list across Indiranagar, Koramangala, Whitefield, Church Street and others.	Near-total, and already in our launch city, neighbourhood by neighbourhood.

The adjacent set

Product	Position
SceneHai	Hyperlocal meetup app; post a vibe, find nearby people. Claims Bangalore, Delhi, Mumbai, Pune, Gurgaon, Jaipur. Free.
Nearlly	Local social app for 21–35s in Indian tier 1 and 2 cities; events, meetups, friends.
Huddl	Small group activities under 10 people — hikes, dinners, game nights, coffee.
Crewda	Join small "crews" nearby around movies, food, fitness, cricket, travel.
Meetup	Incumbent. Large, scheduled, interest-group format. Different shape, same intent.
Partiful, Mint, Offline by Happy Hour, BeThere, Somo Club, Orchy	Invite tooling, curated dinners and community formats adjacent to the same need.

What the research actually establishes

1. **"Map plus create activity plus strangers join plus chat" is not differentiation.** It is the category's table stakes, shipped by at least three teams.
2. **The event-to-crew bridge is also taken.** WorldFlows describes it in the same words we did. It cannot carry the positioning alone.
3. **Bangalore is not virgin territory.** PlsTouchGrass has already done neighbourhood-level curation here.
4. **No product has won the behaviour.** None of these is the reflex app for "what should we do tonight" in Bangalore. The category is crowded but unconsolidated.

The useful question is therefore not *has anyone built this* — they have — but *why has none of them become the default*. Section 10 takes that question seriously.

Verification limit. Product claims above are taken from each product's own marketing pages via search, on 17 Sep 2026. Install counts, active user numbers and live activity density could not be verified: app store and product domains are blocked by this environment's network egress policy. Treat all traction claims, including "India's #1" and "identity-verified", as unaudited vendor marketing. Confirming real density — installing the three direct overlaps and counting live Bangalore Popouts on a Tuesday and a Saturday — is an open task in section 18.

Why no one has won

Six structural failure modes explain the crowded, unconsolidated category. They are ranked by how likely each is to kill Popout specifically. These are hypotheses, not measured findings.

#	Failure mode	Mechanism	Severity
1	Graduation churn	The need expires in about three months. Users who succeed leave permanently and correctly.	Critical
2	Adverse selection	Successful users exit, unsuccessful ones stay. Average member quality falls over time rather than rising.	Critical
3	Gender collapse	Open stranger-meetup products skew heavily male. Once visible, women leave, then men leave.	Critical
4	No-show collapse	Online yes does not equal physical attendance. One abandonment permanently loses a user.	High
5	Empty map	The map's job is to display density. With none, it broadcasts failure at first open.	High
6	Retention leak to WhatsApp	Coordination and friendship both leave. Nothing brings the group back.	Medium

1 and 2. The graduation problem

This is the deepest issue and the one the current thinking has not addressed.

The acute need — *I just moved and know nobody* — has a natural life of roughly one quarter. A user who succeeds builds a friend group and stops needing Popout. A user who fails keeps using it. Over time the composition of the active user base moves away from the people you would want to meet.

This inverts the usual network effect. Most social products get better as they get older. This shape gets worse unless something actively replenishes quality — continuous newcomer inflow, or a reason for successful users to stay that does not depend on loneliness.

The current answer is the friend-group discovery loop. It is unproven and probably weak, for reasons below.

3. Gender collapse

Open-join stranger meetups in India skew male, and the skew compounds. A woman opening a map of Popouts hosted mostly by men aged 24–30 has no reason to join. Her absence makes the product less useful to men, who then leave too.

Nothing in the design as described prevents this. It is the highest-priority unsolved design problem and it was not on the original question list. Section 13 proposes the cheapest available levers.

4. No-shows

The gap between joining and attending is where this category dies quietly. A Popout showing 4 of 4 that produces one person alone in a café does not merely fail once — it removes that user permanently and generates negative word of mouth.

This is also the most tractable problem, which is why section 11 proposes building the wedge here.

5. The empty map

A map is a density display. At launch there is no density, so the map's function is to show the user that the product is empty, once, at the moment of highest intent. Several competitors appear to have led with the map for the same reason we want to: it demonstrates well and scales badly from zero.

This argues for the map being a V1 surface but not the *only* surface, and for principle 5 being enforced literally.

6. The retention leak, and a challenge to the current answer

The stated retention plan is: people meet, move to WhatsApp, then later return as a group to decide what to do. The first two steps are certain. The third is an assumption.

A settled friend group asking “what should we do” opens Instagram, asks in the group, or repeats last weekend. Discovery for existing groups is a lower-frequency behaviour, in direct competition with District, BookMyShow, Zomato and Instagram, all of which have vastly better inventory. Popout would enter that fight with no supply advantage.

This section’s recommendation: treat the friend-group loop as a hypothesis to be tested cheaply, not as the retention model. If retention depends on it and it fails, there is no second plan. A ritual — a recurring Popout at a fixed time and place that happens whether or not anyone signs up — is a cheaper and more testable retention mechanism than group discovery.

Differentiation

The bet: Popout wins on the plan actually happening, not on discovery. Discovery is solved and duplicated. Attendance is not.

Every competitor optimises the top of the funnel — more pins, more categories, better map. The funnel breaks at the bottom, between *joined* and *showed up*. A product that reliably converts a join into four people in a room has something none of the others demonstrably has, and it is a quality users can feel on their first use.

Candidate wedges considered

Wedge	Claim	Verdict
Better map or UI	Prettier, faster, nicer pins	Rejected. Not defensible, not noticeable, already matched.
Event-to-crew bridge	Discovery creates social interaction	Rejected as the primary wedge. WorldFlows ships it. Keep it as a feature.
Event inventory depth	More Bangalore events than anyone	Deferred. Real but slow, and contested by District and BookMyShow. A phase-3 moat, not a wedge.
Cohort focus	Own one community completely, not a city	Adopted as strategy, see section 12. Solves density, not differentiation.
Reliability of the plan	The Popout you join actually happens	Adopted as the wedge.

What reliability means concretely

The unit of reliability is a **host** — a named, accountable person who has committed to being physically present. A pin has no stake in the outcome. A host does.

Four mechanisms, none of which require novel technology:

1. **Hosted by default.** Every Popout has one accountable host, shown by name with their attendance history. A Popout without a host does not publish.
2. **Confirmation gate.** Three hours before start, every member gets one message with two options: confirm, or drop. Silence counts as a drop and frees the seat. This converts a soft yes into a hard commitment and surfaces the real number before anyone travels.
3. **It happens anyway.** The host commits to attending at the minimum viable number, usually two. A Popout that never falls below "the host will be there" cannot strand anyone.
4. **Attendance is the only reputation that counts.** Not stars, not reviews. Confirmed-and-attended versus confirmed-and-absent, visible on the profile. Section 13 details it.

Is this defensible

Partly, and honestly not for long on its own. Any competitor can add a confirmation gate in a week.

What compounds is the second-order effect. Reliability produces an attendance record. Attendance records produce a pool of proven hosts. A city with fifty reliable hosts is a supply asset that cannot be cloned by copying a feature, because it took months of real meetings to build. The feature is copyable; the roster is not.

Revised positioning to test alongside the current one:

Small plans that actually happen.

This is narrower than "find something to do, find someone to do it with", and narrower is the point. The broad version is what every competitor already says.

Go-to-market and cold start

Launch into a cohort, not a geography. Density is the whole problem, and a cohort is a place where density already exists.

The chicken-and-egg is standard: no users means an empty map, an empty map means users leave, which means nobody creates Popouts. The proposed escape is events populating the map first. That helps, but events alone produce a directory, not a social

product — and a directory competes with District and BookMyShow on their terms.

Why cohort beats neighbourhood

"Launch in Koramangala" sounds concrete but is not. Koramangala holds hundreds of thousands of people with no shared context, no shared channel to reach them, and no reason to trust each other. A cohort has all three.

Cohort	Why it works	How to reach it
Co-living operators (Colive, Zolo, Settl)	Hundreds of new-to-Bangalore singles per property, already co-located. The operator wants resident retention, so incentives align.	Partner with one property manager; posters, WhatsApp groups, a launch event
New-joiner cohorts at one large employer	Shared context, shared location, an existing internal channel, and an acute need in the first 90 days	Internal groups, one seeded host per cohort
Gated apartment complexes	Physical density and existing resident groups	Resident WhatsApp admins
One neighbourhood, open	Matches the map metaphor	Weakest. No channel, no trust, no shared context

Recommendation: one co-living operator plus one employer cohort. Target roughly 300 reachable people in a two-kilometre radius, which is dense enough that a map is never empty.

Organizer distribution

Event organizers are a real channel but a **phase 2** one, not a cold-start one.

The pitch in the original thinking — *we will list your event free and link to your booking page* — is worth close to nothing. Organizers already have District, BookMyShow and Insider. Free listing on a product with no users is not a benefit.

The pitch that works has to be specific, and can only be made after it has happened once:

"We fill your dead Tuesdays. We send groups of four who would not have come alone."

Solo-attendee-to-group conversion is the genuine value, because it creates demand that did not previously exist rather than reallocating it. Target recurring organizers: one comedy club running 15 shows a month beats 15 one-off organizers on every dimension — acquisition cost, inventory freshness, relationship depth.

Sequence:

```

flowchart TD
    A[Seed one cohort<br/>~300 reachable people] --> B[Run hosted Popouts<br/>manually, weekly]
    B --> C[Prove attendance<br/>and repeat rate]
    C --> D[Approach organizers with<br/>we sent you 12 people]
    D --> E[Organizer distributes<br/>going solo? find people]
    E --> F[Their audience becomes<br/>our users]

```

Step D is impossible before step C. Attempting organizer partnerships first is the most likely way to waste the first two months.

Referral

Every Popout is a public page, which makes every Popout an acquisition surface. Three distributors, all free:

1. **Guest invites a friend.** WhatsApp message with the event, time and "join Shuvam". No signup wall to view.
2. **Host fills seats.** A Popout at 1 of 4 is a motivated distributor. The share prompt appears exactly when the host is most motivated.
3. **Organizer promotes.** "Going solo? Find people to go with" on their own channels.

The critical constraint: **a shared link must render completely to a signed-out visitor**, with a correct WhatsApp preview. Authentication happens at join, never at view. Getting this wrong breaks the only free acquisition channel.

Trust and safety

Trust is earned through behaviour, not bought through verification. Identity documents are expensive, slow to implement, and a weak predictor of whether someone is decent to meet. Attendance history is cheap and a much better one.

This is not a claim that verification never matters. It is a claim about sequencing: do not build KYC infrastructure before proving people will meet at all.

The progressive trust ladder

Stage	Earned by	Unlocks
New	Google sign-in, complete profile	Join open Popouts
Attended	One confirmed attendance	Create Popouts
Reliable	Three attendances, no unexplained absences	Badge shown on profile and Popouts
Trusted	Ten attendances, clean record, no upheld reports	Host larger Popouts, host in restricted categories

The ladder is free to run, reads honestly to users, and produces exactly the signal the reliability wedge needs.

The safety floor for V1

Four things ship with V1, non-negotiably:

1. **Public places only.** Venue must be a public establishment. No homes, no private addresses, enforced in the create form.
2. **Minimum three people.** A Popout does not proceed at two. Two-person meetings are a date, not a Popout, and carry different risk.
3. **Report and block on every surface.** One tap from any profile, Popout or message. A block hides both users from each other everywhere.
4. **Host removal.** A host can remove any member from their own Popout without explanation.

No in-app DMs. Group threads only. One-to-one contact with strangers is the primary harassment vector, and removing it costs almost nothing at this stage.

Gender balance — the unsolved problem

Section 10 named this as a critical risk. The available levers are cheap, unproven, and must be instrumented from day one.

Lever	Mechanism	Cost
Bring-a-friend default	Women can join as a pair, occupying two seats in one action	Low
Host-set eligibility	Any host can restrict a Popout by gender, including women-only	Low, already in the model

Lever	Mechanism	Cost
Seed the host roster deliberately	Recruit the first 20 hosts at roughly even gender split before opening	Time only
Publish the ratio internally	Track weekly. Treat a skew past 70:30 as a product incident	Free
Women-only Popouts as a first-class category	Not a filter buried in settings but a visible category	Low

This will not be solved by a feature. It is solved, if at all, by who the first hundred users are. That makes it a launch-sequencing decision, taken before the first line of go-to-market spend.

What we are choosing not to do, and the risk we accept

No phone OTP, no ID verification, no background checks in V1. The accepted risk is that a bad actor can create an account with a Google address and a false name.

The mitigations are structural rather than identity-based: public venues, groups of three or more, no private messaging, visible attendance history, and one-tap reporting. If a serious incident occurs, phone verification ships immediately — it is a days-long change, and the code should not make it hard to add.

Metrics and kill criteria

North star: completed Popouts per week — a Popout where three or more people confirmed and attended. Not sign-ups, not pins created, not downloads. Only meetings that happened.

Every vanity metric in this category measures intent. Intent is abundant and worthless here. The scarce thing is attendance.

The funnel

Stage	Metric	Target at week 8	Why it matters
Reach	Saw a Popout page	—	Top of funnel, not a goal
Activation	Joined a first Popout	40% of signups	Measures whether the map is convincing

Stage	Metric	Target at week 8	Why it matters
Conversion	Attended after joining	70%	The wedge. If this fails, nothing else matters.
Repeat	Attended a second within 30 days	40%	Measures whether the experience was good
Supply	Popouts created by someone other than the founder	3 per week	Measures whether it is a product or a service
Host depth	Distinct people who hosted twice	5	The compounding asset
Balance	Gender ratio of attendees	No worse than 65:35	Leading indicator of collapse

Secondary diagnostics

- **Time from open to join** — above 3 minutes suggests the map is not answering the question.
- **Fill rate** — proportion of seats filled at start time. Below 50% means Popouts look dead to the next visitor.
- **Drop-at-confirmation rate** — high is fine and healthy. It means the gate is working. Silent no-shows are the failure, not honest drops.
- **Share-to-join conversion** — tests whether the referral loop is real or decorative.

Kill criteria

These are committed now, before there is anything to rationalise. Evaluated at **week 8 of the pilot**, on at least 8 completed Popouts.

Signal	Kill threshold	What it would mean
Attendance after joining	Below 60%	The core behaviour does not work. No feature fixes this.
Second attendance within 30 days	Below 30%	The experience is not good enough to repeat.
Popouts created by others	Fewer than 3 per week	It is a service the founder performs, not a product.

Signal	Kill threshold	What it would mean
Repeat hosts other than the founder	Fewer than 3	No supply side. Cannot scale past one person's energy.
Gender ratio	Worse than 75:25 and not improving	Section 10 failure mode 3 is in progress.
Founder-hosted share at week 8	Above 50%	Same as above: no organic supply.

Decision rule: any two red at week 8 is a kill. Not a pivot, not one more month. A kill.

One red is a diagnosis, and the response is to fix that specific thing and re-measure over four more weeks.

The purpose of writing these down now is that they will be very easy to argue with later. Traction in this category is always explainable. "We just need more density" is the sentence that keeps these products alive for two years past the point where the answer was already known.

Business model

No revenue in V1, and no pricing experiments until density exists. Charging lonely people a monthly fee to make friends is the obvious model and the wrong one: it taxes the exact users who have not yet received value, and it selects for desperation.

The more interesting long-term business is a **marketplace for real-world leisure capacity**.

Restaurants, cafés, bowling alleys, comedy clubs, workshops and activity centres all run at partial capacity on predictable days. That unused capacity is perishable and currently unsold. A venue with empty lanes on a Tuesday will happily discount them, because the alternative revenue is zero.

Popout sits at an unusual point in that market. It does not merely redirect existing demand — it **manufactures** demand, by converting people who would not have attended alone into groups of four who do. That is a genuinely different contribution from a listing site, and it is what justifies a commission.

Horizon	Revenue line	Precondition
V1	None	—

Horizon	Revenue line	Precondition
Phase 3	Commission on bookings driven through Popout	Provable attribution: the venue can see we sent the group
Phase 3	Promoted placement for venues on the map	Enough organic pins that promotion is distinguishable from filler
Phase 4	Venue tools — publish capacity, fill dead nights	50+ recurring venue partners
Phase 4	Premium consumer features	Only features that do not gate safety or core use

Two rules to hold from the start. **Never charge for safety** — reporting, blocking and trust signals stay free forever. And **never let paid placement outrank a real Popout**, because the moment the map is an ad surface, the density it displays stops being true.

This section is directional. None of it should influence a V1 build decision.

Technical architecture

Constraint: one developer, no budget, weeks not months. Every choice below optimises for shipping speed and near-zero fixed cost, and accepts scaling limits that will not bind before the kill criteria are evaluated.

Layer	Choice	Why
Frontend	Next.js (App Router), TypeScript, Tailwind	Server-rendered public pages, which the share loop requires
Hosting	Vercel free tier	Zero cost, instant deploys, preview URLs
Database	Supabase Postgres	Postgres with row-level security, generous free tier
Auth	Supabase Auth, Google provider only	No OTP cost, no password handling
Realtime	Supabase Realtime	Group chat without running a socket server
Map	MapLibre GL with free vector tiles	No Google Maps billing, no key management
Geocoding	Venue autocomplete, cached	Avoids per-call map billing

Layer	Choice	Why
Notifications	WhatsApp deep links in V1	Push requires an app; the confirmation gate can be a link

Data model

Six tables. A Crew is a Popout with an `event_id`, not a separate table.

Table	Key fields
<code>profiles</code>	<code>id</code> (= auth user), name, age, gender, area, photo_url, bio
<code>events</code>	id, title, venue, lat, lng, starts_at, price, booking_url, organizer
<code>popouts</code>	id, host_id, event_id (nullable), title, venue, lat, lng, starts_at, max_people, min_age, max_age, gender_pref, status
<code>popout_members</code>	popout_id, user_id, status (joined / confirmed / attended / dropped / no_show)
<code>messages</code>	id, popout_id, user_id, body, created_at
<code>reports</code>	id, reporter_id, subject_type, subject_id, reason, created_at

`popout_members.status` is where the entire reliability wedge lives. It is the difference between a product that measures joins and one that measures attendance.

Decisions taken

- **Mobile web, not native.** Every shared link opens instantly. No install wall at the moment of highest intent.
- **Server-rendered public pages.** A Popout link must render fully for a signed-out visitor with correct WhatsApp preview metadata. This is a hard requirement of the referral loop, not a nicety.
- **Row-level security from the first migration.** Group chat visible only to members, enforced at the database, not in application code.
- **Geography as plain lat/lng with a bounding-box query.** PostGIS is available if needed; at this scale it is not.

Cost envelope

Essentially zero at pilot scale: free tiers on hosting, database and map tiles, and a domain. The first real cost arrives with push notifications or SMS, both deliberately deferred.

Roadmap

Four phases. Each has one question it exists to answer, and no phase starts before the previous one has answered its question.

Phase	Duration	Question it answers	Exit condition
0. Manual pilot	Weeks 1–6	Will strangers who said yes actually show up	8 completed Popouts, attendance measured by hand
1. V1 web app	Weeks 4–10	Does software make it work without a human in the loop	The nine features of section 7, live
2. Cohort density	Weeks 8–16	Can one cohort sustain supply without the founder	3+ organic Popouts a week, 5 repeat hosts
3. Event inventory	Month 4+	Do events drive usage and organizer distribution	20 recurring organizer partners

Phase 0 runs in parallel with the build, not before it

The pilot needs no software: a WhatsApp community, a form, and a spreadsheet. It answers the single most important question — attendance — at near-zero cost and in six weeks.

The original guidance would have been to run phase 0 *first* and build nothing until it passed. That was overruled in favour of building now, which is a defensible call: the build takes weeks, and having the product ready when the pilot data lands avoids dead time.

The risk that creates is real and worth naming. If phase 0 fails, the V1 build is wasted work. The mitigation is to run the pilot **starting this week, in parallel**, so the two finish together and the kill criteria are evaluated on time rather than after a build has created its own momentum.

What ships when

Milestone	Contents
M1	Auth, profile, database schema, deployed skeleton
M2	Map and list, seeded events, Popout detail page
M3	Create, join, leave, share with link previews
M4	Group thread, report and block, host removal
M5	Confirmation gate and attendance tracking

M5 is not optional polish. It is the wedge, and it is the one thing on this list a competitor is not already shipping.

Open questions

Decisions and unknowns that are not yet settled. Each needs an owner and a date.

Needs a decision before the build finishes

- ☐ **Which cohort launches first** — a co-living operator or an employer cohort. This determines the seeding plan and cannot be deferred past M3.
- ☐ **Does the founder host the first twenty Popouts** — and is that sustainable given an introverted founder in a new city. This is the largest unpriced input in the plan.
- ☐ **Is the confirmation gate a WhatsApp link or in-app** — decides whether phone numbers are collected in V1.
- ☐ **Minimum viable Popout size** — the safety floor says three; the host-attends-anyway rule implies two. These conflict and need resolving.

Needs evidence

- ☐ **Live density of the three direct competitors in Bangalore** — install SpurSpace, WorldFlows and PlsTouchGrass; count live Popouts within 5km on a Tuesday and a Saturday. This could not be verified here because app store and product domains are blocked by this environment's network policy. It is the single cheapest piece of research available and it changes the strategy if any of them is already dense.
- ☐ **Do fifteen recent Bangalore arrivals describe the problem as discovery, company or nerve** — the three need materially different products.
- ☐ **Will a venue actually discount a dead Tuesday for a guaranteed group of four** — one conversation answers it.

Unresolved disagreements recorded

Question	Position in this doc	Counter-position
Build the map in V1	Yes, with principle 5 enforced	An empty map is an unrecoverable first impression; a curated list is safer
Friend-group discovery as retention	Treated as an unproven hypothesis	It is the stated retention model in the original concept
Build before pilot evidence	Building now, pilot in parallel	Evidence first would avoid wasted build

These are recorded rather than resolved. They are the places where this document and the original concept do not agree, and they should be revisited at week 8 with data rather than argued now.